

SENATE BILL 979

By Southerland

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 39,
relative to offenses against first responders.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 39, Chapter 16, Part 5, is amended by
adding the following as a new section:

(a) As used in this section:

(1) "First responder" means a law enforcement officer, corrections officer,
firefighter, emergency medical technician, or other emergency service personnel;
and

(2) "Harass" means to knowingly engage in a course of conduct directed
at a first responder that intentionally causes the first responder to feel substantial
emotional distress and serves no legitimate purpose.

(b) It is an offense for a person, after receiving a verbal warning not to approach
from an individual, who the person knows or reasonably should know is a first responder
and who is engaged in the lawful performance of the first responder's official duties, to
knowingly violate the warning and approach or remain within twenty-five feet (25') of the
first responder with the intent to:

(1) Impede or interfere with the first responder's ability to perform the first
responder's official duties;

(2) Threaten the first responder with physical harm; or

(3) Harass the first responder.

(c) A person who violates this section commits a Class B misdemeanor.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect July 1, 2025, the public welfare requiring it.